

Workshop Summary

Session conducted by Miqdad Sulaiman

MANO 2026 – Kerala's First Psychology Students' Conclave

Quick Brief Summary

In this session, Miqdad Sulaiman explains the importance of rapport building, micro-skills (SOLAR), and unconditional positive regard for the success of counseling. He reminds that a counselor should be able to listen to clients while maintaining professional boundaries, understand their psychological difficulties, and make appropriate interventions.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

At the beginning of the speech, Miqdad Sulaiman talks about an unexpected incident he faced during his student days and his encounter with a person. As a psychology student, he explains the importance of listening to people's stories without judging them. He also reminds us that such experiences can occur on a bus or train even before the counseling journey officially begins.

Main Theme: Micro-Skills and Professional Boundaries in Counseling

The main topic of this speech is the importance of the basic micro-skills required to achieve success in the field of counseling, building rapport with the client, the approach towards therapy, and professional boundaries such as time, fees, and confidentiality.

Key Areas Explored

Rapport Building and Micro-Skills (SOLAR)

The relationship with the client, or rapport, is the most important part of counseling. Based on Carl Rogers' person-centered approach, he explains five micro-skills that counselors should know through the acronym 'SOLAR'. 'S' stands for sitting squarely facing the client, and 'O' stands for open posture. Next, 'L' refers to leaning forward slightly as part of active listening, and 'E' denotes comfortable eye contact. 'R' means sitting relaxed. He emphasizes that being prepared to listen to clients calmly, avoiding distractions, is essential for a counselor's success.

Exploration and Unconditional Positive Regard

The speaker clarifies that the first session is mainly for collecting data and listening patiently to the client's stories. Genuineness is very important here. Through Carl Rogers' concept of 'Unconditional Positive Regard', he explains with examples that a counselor should be able to accept clients as they are, no matter how big of a mistake they have made.

Professional Boundaries and Emotional Management

The speaker reminds us that time boundaries, fees, and confidentiality are essential to keep the counseling relationship running smoothly. Strictly adhering to the 45-minute session time and charging professional fees will help the success of therapy. He also discusses situations requiring emotional intervention, such as staying silent and supporting the client when they cry.

Key Insights: Main Principles in Counseling

1. Relationship is the Core: Half of the success of therapy is achieved by establishing a good relationship with the client.
2. The Power of Empathy: Clients can be truly helped only by understanding the root cause of their problems.
3. Non-Judgmental Approach: Do not quickly pre-judge a person without fully understanding the circumstances.
4. The Role of Boundaries: Time schedules, fees, and confidentiality ensure a therapist's professionalism.

Conclusion: The Kintsugi Philosophy and the Goal of Counseling

The speaker concludes his speech by citing the Japanese art of 'Kintsugi' as an example. He reminds us that just like broken pottery is made beautiful by mending it with gold, a counselor's responsibility is to address the psychological distress of individuals who are shattered in life and empower them to live stronger. He concludes his speech by wishing success in this career, which has a commitment to society.

Highlights

Rapport Building and Micro Skills (SOLAR)

Establishing a connection (Rapport) with the client is the most important part of counseling. To make this effective, the 'SOLAR' micro-skill model can be used. (S - Sitting squarely, O - Open

posture, L - Leaning forward, A - Eye contact, R - Relaxed posture). This provides safety and comfort to the client.

First Session and Data Collection

The first counseling session is entirely for listening to the client's story and gathering information (Data Gathering). Instead of suggesting solutions immediately, time should be found to understand their journey.

Professional Boundaries and Confidentiality

Clear boundaries are essential in counseling. Session timing, fee collection, and confidentiality help maintain the professional relationship.

Empathy and Non-Judgmental Approach

Empathy is the ability to understand clients' conditions without judging them (Non-judgmental). Counselors should be careful not to act with preconceptions without fully knowing the circumstances.

Miqdad Sulaiman